‘for it is anything but pleasant to see the spirit of opposition to the government showing itself through all the districts, and to feel that, happen what may, there is no possibility of employing force in support of royal authority [until you return].’ A day later he was writing to Nott with even greater urgency: ‘I regret to say that affairs to the westward are assuming so alarming an appearance, that I begin to fear that the immediate employment of regular troops will be found necessary in support of the authority of the Govt.’[18] Yet Macnaghten’s response when he read Rawlinson’s anxious despatches was as patronising as it was wrong-headed. He accused Rawlinson of ‘taking an unwarrantably gloomy view of our position, and entertaining and disseminating rumours favourable to that view. We have enough of difficulties without adding to the number needlessly . . . I know [such rumours] to be utterly false as regards this part of the country, and have no reason to believe them to be true as regards your portion of the Kingdom.’[19] In a later letter, he again took issue with Rawlinson’s assessment that an uprising was imminent. ‘I do not concur with you as to the difficulty of our position,’ he wrote.

> On the contrary, I think our prospects are most cheering, and with the materials we have there ought to be little or no difficulty . . . The people of this country are very credulous. They believe anything invented to our prejudice, but they will soon learn that we are not the cannibals we are painted . . . Certainly our troops can be no great favourites in a town where they have turned out half the inhabitants for their own accommodation, but I will venture to say there is not a country town in England where soldiers are quartered in which similar excesses have not happened . . .
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> These people are perfect children and they should be treated as such. If we put one naughty boy in the corner the rest will be terrified. We have taken their plaything, power, out of the hands of the Dooranee Chiefs and they are panting in consequence. They did not know how to use it. In their hands it was useless and ever hurtful to their master and we are obliged to transfer it to scholars of our own. They instigate the Moollas, and the Moollas preach to the people, but this will be very temporary.[20]

It was the same in Kohistan, to the north of Kabul. In the summer of 1841 Eldred Pottinger, the former ‘Hero of Herat’, arrived in Charikar with a garrison of Gurkhas to find the British position every bit as indefensible as the Kabul cantonment: the Gurkhas had to camp in tents while their badly located, mud-walled and still gateless barracks was overlooked and dominated by a second much stronger fortress a short distance from it on slightly higher ground. Moreover they had no artillery; yet all around were widespread signs of growing unrest. When one of Pottinger’s assistants was taken aside by a fakir to whom he had given alms, and warned that a